

SUNITA DEVI, *40*

Bulandshahr, Uttar Pradesh

‘They used my dead husband to fool us’

Subhash had died in December 2024, at just 45, after a long, punishing fight with liver disease. He left behind a widow, three sons and his broken autorickshaw parked outside their half-built house. A month after his death, two visitors—an ASHA *didi* and a man who said he was a doctor—arrived at their door, offering to help the family claim a government benefit. But first, they insisted, every photo of Subhash had to be destroyed. They even carried away all ID cards and medical papers. What Sunita didn’t know then was that those strangers had already taken out a Rs 15 lakh insurance policy in Subhash’s name, months before he died. The claim would later be quietly processed. She saw just Rs 20,000. “They used my dead husband to fool us and make money,” says Sunita. “That hurts us more than anything.” ■

HOW THE SCAM BROKE OPEN

The web began to unravel in the early hours of January 17, 2025, when a team of the Sambhal police stopped a black Mahindra Scorpio on suspicion of vehicle theft. Inside, they found two men, Rs 11.45 lakh in cash and 19 debit cards under different names. One of them, Omkareshwar Mishra, carried two ID cards identifying him as a field investigator for firms that check suspicious insurance claims. His phone revealed something bigger: over 100,000 photographs, 30,000 documents and screenshots of big transactions. Many belonged to poor families with large insurance policies in their names.

Anukriti Sharma, additional SP (South) in Sambhal, who led the interception and is now supervising the investigation, says two names—Subhash and Aslam—were the first threads. Police traced the policies linked to them and found lakhs deposited in bank accounts opened in the names of their widows: Sunita and Rukhsar, respectively. The women had seen only a fraction, handed over as “government relief” (see *‘They used my dead husband to fool us’*). Both deaths had been officially recorded as heart attacks, despite long-standing illnesses.

21
Total FIRs registered

4
No. of murder cases

68
Suspects arrested

From there, a pattern emerged. Almost every death occurred within a year of the risk commencement date—the date from which the insurer takes on the risk and agrees to pay claims, if the conditions are met. The cause was always listed as a heart attack. Claims were always cleared. Anukriti says insurers have already flagged thousands of such cases. “Even a conservative estimate,” she warns, “suggests the fraud could cross Rs 1,000 crore.”

MURKY MURDER TRAILS

As investigators dug deeper, they discovered the scam wasn’t only about forged documents. It had turned murderous. Aman and Salim were not the only victims. There was also Dariyab, a 35-year-old severely handicapped beggar from Sambhal. Five policies worth over Rs 50 lakh had been taken out in his name. In July 2024, he was found dead, supposedly in a road accident. Investigators now say he